PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

Best Guess Mock Exam 8: Non-Violent Direct Action and the Birmingham Campaign (1960–63)

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (the response of the police to civil rights demonstrators in Birmingham in May 1963):

• **Inference 1:** Police authorities used extreme, violent force against peaceful child demonstrators.
- *Detail from source:* "Police Commissioner Bull Connor ordered his men to turn high-pressure fire hoses on them. The water was so powerful it knocked them off their feet and ripped their clothes."

• **Inference 2:** The violent police retaliation was exposed publicly to a national audience via the media.
- *Detail from source:* "The sounds of screaming children and barking dogs filled the air, all captured on television cameras."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

"One reason why the Birmingham Campaign (1963) was launched was that Birmingham was widely known as the most segregated city in America." The local SCLC and Alabama Christian Movement for Human Rights had tried to negotiate with local merchants, but white businesses refused to desegregate lunch counters or hire Black workers, and local authorities banned all protests. *Therefore, segregation and the failure of negotiations were a primary cause of why the Birmingham Campaign was launched, as SCLC realized direct action was the only way to break the stalemate.*

"A second reason why the Birmingham Campaign (1963) was launched was to implement 'Project C' (Confrontation) to provoke a federal response." The organizers, led by SCLC, designed a strategy of public demonstrations to provoke a violent reaction from the notorious segregationist **Police Commissioner Bull Connor**. They knew Connor's aggressive methods would expose the brutality of Southern racism. *Therefore, Project C was a key cause of why the Birmingham Campaign was launched, because it aimed to force federal intervention by creating a public crisis that Washington could not ignore.*

"A third reason why the Birmingham Campaign (1963) was launched was to capture national media and television coverage to win public support." Activists knew that visual media would shock the northern public and international community. When Connor used high-pressure water **hoses** and attack dogs against child marchers, the images were broadcast worldwide, generating massive moral outrage. *Therefore, the strategic use of media exposure was a decisive cause of why the Birmingham Campaign was launched, because it mobilized national opinion and forced President Kennedy to draft the Civil Rights Act.*

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for explaining the strategic philosophy of non-violent direct action during the Birmingham campaign. King explains that they did not create the tension, but rather brought it to the surface, and that direct action was necessary to create a "creative tension" that forces a community to negotiate. This content is highly useful because it is supported by my knowledge that King and the SCLC deliberately chose Birmingham in 1963 to force integration after local merchants broke previous promises, showing that the letter accurately outlines their tactical intent. The provenance of a letter written by MLK while imprisoned in Birmingham Jail in April 1963 makes it extremely useful. As a key leader of the movement writing in the midst of the campaign, it represents an authentic, high-stakes defense of their methods against critics, although it naturally downplays any tactical divisions within the civil rights leadership.

Source C is highly useful for demonstrating the opposition and arguments used by local white authorities against the marches. Mayor Boutwell claims that "outside agitators" have caused "unnecessary chaos" and that integration cannot be forced overnight by "street mobs," advocating for calm local discussion instead. This content's utility is supported by my knowledge that white moderates in Birmingham, including local clergy, criticized King's timing and methods, arguing that the protests disrupted progress and polarized the city, which verifies that the Mayor's complaints were representative of local white political opinion. The provenance of a public statement by the newly elected moderate Mayor in May 1963 makes the source very useful because it captures the official segregationist and moderate white resistance at the height of the crisis. However, it is limited because it minimizes the systemic violence and bombings that Black residents faced, framing the conflict purely as a disturbance of the peace.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 views the Birmingham campaign as a **"brilliant tactical victory"** that successfully forced the federal government to draft the Civil Rights Act of 1964. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that its **"immediate achievements on the ground were highly limited"** and triggered a violent white backlash.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have given weight to different sources. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source B, which states that direct action seeks to force a community that has refused to negotiate to "confront the issue", leading to the view that the campaign was a **"brilliant tactical victory"**. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source C, which states that the marches caused "unnecessary chaos, hurting our local merchants", leading to the view that its **"immediate achievements on the ground were highly limited"**.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a large extent with Interpretation 1 that the Birmingham campaign was a highly significant victory that transformed the civil rights struggle. By using children in the marches, the SCLC provoked **Bull Connor** into deploying fire hoses and police dogs, as described in Source A's shocking report of water **knocking them off their feet**. The resulting television footage shocked the nation and put immense pressure on the federal government. President Kennedy declared that Birmingham had forced the administration to act, leading directly to his June 1963 address and the drafting of the Civil Rights Bill. This supports Interpretation 1's claim that the campaign was a **"brilliant tactical victory"** that forced the drafting of the **Civil Rights Act of 1964**.

However, Interpretation 2 is also valid in highlighting that the immediate local impact was limited and met with violent resistance. The actual local desegregation agreement was minimal, and department store integration did not solve systemic housing and employment poverty. As Source C shows, white residents resented the marches, calling them **ill-timed** and causing **unnecessary chaos**. Furthermore, the campaign sparked a wave of segregationist violence, culminating in the KKK bombing of the **Sixteenth Street** Baptist Church in September 1963, which killed four young girls. This confirms Interpretation 2's view that local progress was **"highly limited"** and provoked **"violent white backlash"**.

Overall, while the local gains in Birmingham itself were slow and met with white terror (Interpretation 2), the campaign's national significance was monumental. It succeeded because it nationalized the crisis, turning civil rights into a moral issue that forced the federal government to pass the Civil Rights Act of 1964 (Interpretation 1).